Arabic 011: Lesson 3 Study Guide

Everything for the Lesson 3 exam in one place.

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Vocabulary

Nouns

his family *usratuhu*	أسرتُهُ
son *ibn*	ابن
cousin, male, paternal *ibn ʿamm*	ابن عَمّ
army *jaysh*	جَيش
letter *risaala*	رِسالة
husband *zawj*	زَوج
her husband *zawjuha*	زَوجُها
wife *zawja*	زَوجة
picture *Suura*	صورة
officer *DaabiT*	ضابِط
science *ʿilm*	عِلم
political science *al-ʿuluum as-siyaasiyya*	العُلوم السِّياسِيّة
paternal uncle *ʿamm*	عَمّ
my (paternal) uncle *ʿammii*	عَمّي
extended family *ʿaa'ila*	عائِلة
relative *qariib*	قَريب
college, school in a university *kulliyya*	كُلِّيّة
grandfather / grandmother *jadd / jadda*	جَدّ / جَدّة
history *at-taariikh*	التّارِيخ
law *al-Huquuq*	الحُقُوق
religion *ad-diin*	الدِّين
medicine *aT-Tibb*	الطِّبّ
anthropology *ʿilm al-insaan*	عِلْم الإِنْسان
sociology *ʿilm al-ijtimaaʿ*	عِلْم الاِجْتِماع
psychology *ʿilm an-nafs*	عِلْم النَّفْس
engineering *al-handasa*	الهَنْدَسة
the idafa (construct phrase) *al-iDaafa*	الإِضافة
sons *abnaa'*	أَبْناء
cousins, male, paternal *abnaa' ʿamm*	أَبْناء عَمّ
armies *juyuush*	جُيُوش
letters *rasaa'il*	رَسائِل
husbands *azwaaj*	أَزْواج
wives *zawjaat*	زَوْجات
pictures *Suwar*	صُوَر
officers *Dubbaat*	ضُبّاط
sciences *ʿuluum*	عُلُوم
paternal uncles *aʿmaam*	أَعْمام
extended families *ʿaa'ilaat*	عائِلات
relatives *aqaarib*	أَقارِب
colleges, schools in a university *kulliyyaat*	كُلِّيّات

Verbs

I feel (with بِـ) *ashʿuru bi*	أَشْعُرُ بِـ
he teaches *yudarris*	يُدَرِّس
I know *aʿrif*	أعرِف

Numbers

twenty *ʿishruun*	عِشْرُون
thirty *thalaathuun*	ثَلاثُون
forty *arbaʿuun*	أَرْبَعُون
fifty *khamsuun*	خَمْسُون
sixty *sittuun*	سِتُّون
seventy *sabʿuun*	سَبْعُون
eighty *thamaanuun*	ثَمانُون
ninety *tisʿuun*	تِسْعُون
one hundred *miʾa*	مِئة
eleven *aHadaʿashara*	أَحَدَ عَشَرَ
twelve *ithnaaʿashara*	اِثْنا عَشَرَ
thirteen *thalaathataʿashara*	ثَلاثَةَ عَشَرَ
fourteen *arbaʿataʿashara*	أَرْبَعةَ عَشَرَ
fifteen *khamsataʿashara*	خَمْسةَ عَشَرَ
sixteen *sittataʿashara*	سِتّةَ عَشَرَ
seventeen *sabʿataʿashara*	سَبْعةَ عَشَرَ
eighteen *thamaaniyataʿashara*	ثَمانِيةَ عَشَرَ
nineteen *tisʿataʿashara*	تِسْعةَ عَشَرَ

Phrases and particles

actually, in reality *fi l-Haqiiqa*	في الحَقيقة

Other

now *al-aan*	الآن

Family Terms

Father's side uses عَمّ / عَمّة; mother's side uses خال / خالة. A cousin is اِبْن or بِنْت plus the uncle or aunt word.

Singular	Plural	Meaning
عَمّ	أَعْمام	uncle, father's brother
عَمّة	عَمّات	aunt, father's sister
خال	أَخْوال	uncle, mother's brother
خالة	خالات	aunt, mother's sister
زَوْجة عَمّ / زَوْجة خال	زَوْجات عَمّ / زَوْجات خال	uncle's wife
زَوْج عَمّة / زَوْج خالة	أَزْواج عَمّة / أَزْواج خالة	aunt's husband
اِبْن عَمّ / بِنْت عَمّ	أَبْناء عَمّ / بَنات عَمّ	cousin (child of father's brother)
اِبْن عَمّة / بِنْت عَمّة	أَبْناء عَمّة / بَنات عَمّة	cousin (child of father's sister)
اِبْن خال / بِنْت خال	أَبْناء خال / بَنات خال	cousin (child of mother's brother)
اِبْن خالة / بِنْت خالة	أَبْناء خالة / بَنات خالة	cousin (child of mother's sister)

grandfather / grandmother	أَجْداد / جَدّات	جَدّ / جَدّة
relative	أَقارِب	قَرِيب

In a plural idafa term only the first word is pluralized: أَبْناء عَمّ (male cousins, sons of paternal uncles).

Wider use

- عَمِّي، عَمَّتِي، خالِي، خالَتِي are also used for distant relatives, in-laws, and respected older people.
- Father-in-law: عَمِّي. Mother-in-law: زَوْجة عَمِّي or خالَتِي. Stepmother: خالَتِي.

Chains

Longer terms are idafa chains: اِبْن عَمّ والِد مَها (Maha's father's cousin). A possessive goes on the end only: رَقْم تِلِفُونِي (my phone number).

Culture Notes

- **Housework (شُغْل البَيْت).** Both spouses increasingly work outside the home, and extended family often helps with childcare. Traditionally the wife handles the home and the husband handles errands outside it.
- **Being alone.** Spending time alone (except to work or study) is generally seen as undesirable. Frequent visits with family, neighbors, and friends mean people are rarely alone. That's why Maha calling herself وَحِيدة says a lot.
- Extended family matters more than in the US: frequent visits, and cousins are often close friends.
- Arab universities are split into separate colleges (كُلِّيّة الآداب، كُلِّيّة التِّجارة), medicine and law are undergraduate degrees, and students choose humanities or sciences in high school.

The Idafa

What idafa does

Idafa expresses possession or "of" by placing nouns next to each other: the second noun specifies or possesses the first.

The rules

- Only the very last noun in the chain is allowed to carry ال or a tanwiin ending.
- Every noun before the last takes neither ال nor tanwiin; the phrase takes its definiteness from the last noun.
- A ة on the first noun is pronounced "-t".
- The second noun, and any after it, is genitive (see Case Endings).

جَامِعَةُ جُورجْتَاون (Georgetown University, literally "the university of Georgetown"). بَيْتُ الأُسْتَاذِ (the professor's house).

Idafa or noun + adjective?

بَيْت الأُسْتاذ (the professor's house, two nouns) vs البَيْت الكَبِير (the big house, noun + adjective, both with ال).

Possessive endings in a chain

Every noun but the last stays bare. A possessive goes on the end only: رَقْم تِلِفُونِي (my phone number).

Where adjectives go in an idafa

An adjective goes after the entire idafa; gender and number agreement show which noun it describes.

غُرْفَةُ الطَّالِبَةِ الجَدِيدَةِ (the new [female] student's room): جَدِيدَةِ is feminine singular and agrees with الطَّالِبَةِ (the student); غرفة is also feminine, so context decides.

Suffixes replace the second noun

A possessive suffix can replace the second noun. كِتَابُ الطَّالِب (the student's book) becomes كِتَابُهُ (his book).

Longer chains

Chains of three or more follow the same rules: only the last noun can take ال or tanwiin. The example below means "the door of the professor's house."

The Idafa, Continued

Idafa with a possessive suffix as the last term

A possessive suffix can serve as the final term: ابن عَمّي (my paternal cousin) is ابن + عمّ with the "my" suffix on the second noun, عمّ.

Long idafa chains in family vocabulary

Kinship terms are built with idafa: ابن عَمّ (paternal male cousin, literally "son of a paternal uncle"), زَوجة عَمّي (my paternal uncle's wife).

Academic subjects

Academic subjects are usually themselves idafa constructions: عِلمُ النَفس (psychology, literally "the science of the self"), عِلمُ الاجتِماع (sociology, "the science of society/gathering"), عِلمُ الإنسان (anthropology, "the science of the human being").

Pronouns and Possessive Endings

Independent subject pronouns

Arabic marks gender in the second and third person and has a dual. The verb ending already shows the subject, so independent pronouns like أنا or هو are used mainly for emphasis, contrast, or to open a nominal sentence.

There's no "it": use هُوَ for masculine things and هِيَ for feminine things.

Possessive suffixes

Possessives are suffixes attached to the noun, and they make it definite. A final ة becomes ت before a suffix.

Meaning	Subject	Suffix	Example
I	أَنَا	ي	إسمي *(ismii)*
you (m. sg.)	أَنْتَ	كَ	إسمُكَ *(ismuka)*
you (f. sg.)	أَنْتِ	كِ	إسمُكِ *(ismuki)*
he / it (m.)	هُوَ	هُ	إسمُهُ *(ismuhu)*
she / it (f.)	هِيَ	ها	إسمُها *(ismuha)*
we	نَحْنُ	نا	إسمُنا *(ismunaa)*
you (m. dual)	أَنْتُمَا	كُمَا	إسمُكُما *(ismukumaa)*
you (f. dual)	أَنْتُمَا	كُمَا	إسمُكُما *(ismukumaa)*
they (m. dual)	هُمَا	هُمَا	إسمُهُما *(ismuhumaa)*

they (f. dual)	هُمَا	هُمَا	إسمُهُما *(ismuhumaa)*
you (m. pl.)	أَنْتُمْ	كُمْ	إسمُكُم *(ismukum)*
you (f. pl.)	أَنْتُنَّ	كُنَّ	إسمُكُنَّ *(ismukunna)*
they (m. pl.)	هُمْ	هُمْ	إسمُهُم *(ismuhum)*
they (f. pl.)	هُنَّ	هُنَّ	إسمُهُنَّ *(ismuhunna)*

Suffixes on prepositions

The same suffixes attach to prepositions.

مِنْهُ = ـهُ + مِن (from him). مَعَهُم = ـهُم + مَعَ (with them). إِلَيْكَ = ـكَ + إلى (to you).

Suffixes in an idafa

A suffix can stand in for the second noun of an idafa: اسْمُ أُخْتِي means "my sister's name," built from اسم (name) and أُخْتِي (my sister, أُخْت + "my").

Plurals: Sound and Broken

Sound plurals

- Sound masculine plural: ـونَ / ـينَ, used mainly for human male nouns and active participles: مُوَظَّف → مُوَظَّفونَ (employee → employees)
- Sound feminine plural: ـاتٌ, used for most human female nouns and many non-human feminine nouns: زَميلة → زَميلات (classmate, f. → classmates, f.)

Broken plurals: common patterns

A broken plural rearranges the root consonants into a new pattern. Common patterns (see Broken Plural Patterns for the full set):

Singular pattern	Example	Plural pattern	Example
faʿl	زَوج → أزواج	afʿaal	husband → husbands
fuʿl	عِلم → عُلوم	fuʿuul	science → sciences
faʿiil	قَريب → أقارِب	afaaʿil	relative → relatives
faaʿil	ضابِط → ضُبّاط	fuʿaal	officer → officers

Memorize each noun together with its plural.

Plural agreement

- **People** take plural adjectives: طُلّاب أَمْرِيكِيُّون، طالِبات أَمْرِيكِيّات.
- A **mixed group** of men and women takes the masculine plural: الطُّلّاب وَالطّالِبات مَشْغُولُون.
- **Things** (and animals) in the plural act like a **feminine singular**: مُدُن كَبِيرة، سَيّارات يابانِيّة، الأُمَم المُتَّحِدة. Families count as things: الأُسَر المِصْرِيّة كَبِيرة.
- Most nisba adjectives take ـات / ـون, but عَرَبِيّ ← عَرَب is irregular.

Sound plurals of nationalities and professions

Men take ـُون (the formal subject form) or ـِين (other positions, and what is heard in speech); women take ـات.

Singular (m.)	Plural (m.)	Plural (f.)	Meaning
مِصْرِيّ	مِصْرِيُّون / مِصْرِيِّين	مِصْرِيّات	Egyptian
مُتَرْجِم	مُتَرْجِمُون / مُتَرْجِمِين	مُتَرْجِمات	translator
مُتَخَصِّص	مُتَخَصِّصُون / مُتَخَصِّصِين	مُتَخَصِّصات	specialist
مَشْغُول	مَشْغُولُون / مَشْغُولِين	مَشْغُولات	busy
مُوَظَّف	مُوَظَّفُون / مُوَظَّفِين	مُوَظَّفات	employee

Plurals in the vocabulary

People: broken plurals

Singular	Plural	Meaning
رَجُل	رِجال	man
طالِب	طُلّاب	student
وَلَد	أَوْلاد	boy, child
خال	أَخْوال	uncle (mother's brother)
صاحِب	أَصْحاب	friend
أُسْتاذ	أَساتِذة	professor
دُكْتُور	دَكاتِرة	doctor
سَيِّد	سادة	Mr., gentleman
أَخ	إِخْوة	brother
جار	جِيران	neighbor
عَرَبِيّ	عَرَب	Arab

People: men's sound plural (ـُون / ـِين)

Singular	Plural	Meaning
مِصْرِيّ	مِصْرِيُّون / مِصْرِيِّين	Egyptian
لُبْنانِيّ	لُبْنانِيُّون / لُبْنانِيِّين	Lebanese
مُتَرْجِم	مُتَرْجِمُون / مُتَرْجِمِين	translator
مُتَخَصِّص	مُتَخَصِّصُون / مُتَخَصِّصِين	specialist
مَشْغُول	مَشْغُولُون / مَشْغُولِين	busy
مُوَظَّف	مُوَظَّفُون / مُوَظَّفِين	employee

People: women's plural (ـات)

Singular	Plural	Meaning
بِنْت	بَنات	girl, daughter
أُخْت	أَخَوات	sister
اِمْرَأة	نِساء	woman
طالِبة	طالِبات	student (f)
أُسْتاذة	أَساتِذات	professor (f)
سَيِّدة	سَيِّدات	lady, Mrs.
خالة	خالات	aunt (mother's sister)
جارة	جارات	neighbor (f)
مِصْرِيّة	مِصْرِيّات	Egyptian (f)
فِلَسْطِينِيّة	فِلَسْطِينِيّات	Palestinian (f)
مُتَرْجِمة	مُتَرْجِمات	translator (f)
مُتَخَصِّصة	مُتَخَصِّصات	specialist (f)
مَشْغُولة	مَشْغُولات	busy (f)
مُوَظَّفة	مُوَظَّفات	employee (f)

Things: broken plurals

Singular	Plural	Meaning
اِسْم	أَسْماء	name
عَمَل	أَعْمال	work, job
خَبَر	أَخْبار	news item
باب	أَبْواب	door
كِتاب	كُتُب	book
مَدِينة	مُدُن	city
أُسْرة	أُسَر	family
غُرْفة	غُرَف	room
قِصّة	قِصَص	story
بَيْت	بُيُوت	house
دَرْس	دُرُوس	lesson
صَفّ	صُفُوف	class
فَصْل	فُصُول	class, semester

بَنْك	بُنُوك	bank
فِلْس	فُلُوس	money
شارِع	شَوارِع	street
دَفْتَر	دَفاتِر	notebook
شُبّاك	شَبابِيك	window
مِنْطَقة	مَناطِق	area
مَكْتَب	مَكاتِب	office, desk

Things: ـات plurals

Singular	Plural	Meaning
جامِعة	جامِعات	university
طائِرة	طائِرات	airplane
سَيّارة	سَيّارات	car
وِلاية	وِلايات	state
ساعة	ساعات	clock, hour
لُغة	لُغات	language
كَلِمة	كَلِمات	word
صَفْحة	صَفَحات	page
طاوِلة	طاوِلات	table
وَرَقة	وَرَقات	sheet of paper
بِناية	بِنايات	building
تَرْجَمة	تَرْجَمات	translation
مَكْتَبة	مَكْتَبات	library

Lesson 3 nouns

Singular	Plural	Meaning
اِبْن	أَبْناء	son
عَمّ	أَعْمام	paternal uncle
عَمّة	عَمّات	paternal aunt
جَيْش	جُيُوش	army
رِسالة	رَسائِل	letter
زَوْج	أَزْواج	husband
زَوْجة	زَوْجات	wife

صُورة	صُوَر	picture
ضابِط	ضُبّاط	officer
عِلْم	عُلُوم	science
عائِلة	عائِلات	family
قَرِيب	أَقارِب	relative
كُلِّيّة	كُلِّيّات	college

Adjectives and Agreement

Word order

Adjectives follow their noun. "A big house" is بَيْتٌ كَبِيرٌ, literally "house big."

Three-way agreement

An adjective agrees with its noun in gender, number, and definiteness.

- **Gender:** a masculine noun takes a masculine adjective; a feminine noun (usually marked by ة) takes a feminine adjective (usually also marked by ة).
- **Definiteness:** if the noun carries ال, the adjective takes ال too.
- **Number:** a plural noun for people takes a plural adjective; a plural noun for things takes a feminine singular adjective.

Phrase	Transliteration	Meaning
بَيْتٌ كَبِيرٌ	baytun kabiirun	a big house
البَيْتُ الكَبِيرُ	al-baytu l-kabiiru	the big house
بُيُوتٌ كَبِيرَةٌ	buyuutun kabiiratun	big houses (plural noun for a thing, but singular feminine adjective)

Stacking more than one adjective

Several adjectives each agree with the noun and may be joined by و ("and"): بَيْتٌ كَبِيرٌ وَجَدِيدٌ (a big and new house).

Adjectives inside an idafa

An adjective describing part of an idafa goes after the whole phrase; agreement shows which noun it modifies.

Nisba Adjectives

The nisba adjective (النِّسْبة) turns a noun, most often a place name, into an adjective of origin or affiliation. Add ـِيّ (masculine) or ـِيَّة (feminine).

What to strip before adding the suffix

Strip these from the noun, if present:

- the definite article ال
- a feminine ة ending
- a final long vowel

Three worked examples

العِراق (Iraq) loses ال, leaving عِراق, plus the nisba suffix gives عِراقِيّ (Iraqi, m.) and عِراقِيّة (Iraqi, f.).

السُّعودِيّة (Saudi Arabia) loses both ال and the feminine ة, leaving سُعود, plus the suffix gives سُعودِيّ (Saudi, m.) and سُعودِيّة (Saudi, f.).

سوريا (Syria) loses its final long vowel (ا), leaving سور, plus the suffix gives سورِيّ (Syrian, m.) and سورِيّة (Syrian, f.).

Agreement and word order

Like any adjective, a nisba adjective agrees in gender with the noun it describes and follows it in word order: أنا مِصْرِيّ (I am Egyptian, said by a man), هي مِصْرِيّة (she is Egyptian).

Not just countries

Any noun can take a nisba ending to mean "relating to X": سِياسة (politics) gives سِياسِيّ (political), as in العُلوم السِّياسِيّة (political science).

Countries of the Arab world

Country	Arabic	Nisba (m. / f.)
Jordan	الأُرْدُنّ	أُرْدُنِّيّ / أُرْدُنِّيّة
United Arab Emirates	الإِماراتُ	إِماراتِيّ / إِماراتِيّة
Bahrain	البَحْرَيْن	بَحْرَيْنِيّ / بَحْرَيْنِيّة
Tunisia	تُونِس	تُونِسِيّ / تُونِسِيّة
Algeria	الجَزائِر	جَزائِرِيّ / جَزائِرِيّة
Djibouti	جِيبُوتِي	جِيبُوتِيّ / جِيبُوتِيّة
Saudi Arabia	السُّعُودِيّة	سُعُودِيّ / سُعُودِيّة
Sudan	السُّودان	سُودانِيّ / سُودانِيّة
Syria	سُورِيا	سُورِيّ / سُورِيّة
Somalia	الصُّومال	صُومالِيّ / صُومالِيّة
Iraq	العِراق	عِراقِيّ / عِراقِيّة
Oman	عُمان	عُمانِيّ / عُمانِيّة
Palestine	فِلَسْطِين	فِلَسْطِينِيّ / فِلَسْطِينِيّة
Qatar	قَطَر	قَطَرِيّ / قَطَرِيّة
Comoros	جُزُر القَمَر	قُمُرِيّ / قُمُرِيّة
Kuwait	الكُوَيْت	كُوَيْتِيّ / كُوَيْتِيّة
Lebanon	لُبْنان	لُبْنانِيّ / لُبْنانِيّة
Libya	لِيبِيا	لِيبِيّ / لِيبِيّة
Egypt	مِصْر	مِصْرِيّ / مِصْرِيّة
Morocco	المَغْرِب	مَغْرِبِيّ / مَغْرِبِيّة

Mauritania	مُورِيتانيا	مُورِيتانِيّ / مُورِيتانِيّة
Yemen	اليَمَن	يَمَنِيّ / يَمَنِيّة

The Nominal Sentence and Negation

A nominal sentence (الجُملة الاسمِيّة) is a subject followed by its predicate, with no verb "to be."

Negating with laysa

Negate with لَيسَ (laysa), a verb that conjugates for person and goes before the predicate.

Meaning	Arabic
I am not a translator	لَستُ مُتَرجِماً
She is not busy	لَيسَت مَشغولة
They are not employees	لَيسوا مُوَظَّفين

The predicate after laysa is accusative: لَستُ مُتَرجِماً ends in -اً, not the nominative -ٌ.

Kinds of predicate

- The خَبَر can be an adjective, a noun, a verb phrase, or a place phrase: مَكْتَب القَبُول فِي هَذِهِ البِناية، مَهما تَسْكُن فِي نِيويُورْك.
- Both parts agree in gender and number: الدُّرُوس صَعْبة، هِيَ حَرّانة، أَنْتُمْ مَشْغُولُون.

Fronting the predicate

A prepositional-phrase predicate ("with me," "in the office") usually comes first, before the subject: عِندي أُخت ("I have a sister," literally "at me [is] a sister"). The subject that follows is indefinite.

Case Endings

What iʿraab is

In formal, fully vowelled Arabic a short-vowel ending marks a noun or adjective's grammatical role (iʿraab). Spoken dialects have largely dropped these endings.

The three cases

Case	Name	Ending	Used for
Nominative	مَرْفُوع	Damma (-u, or -un when indefinite)	the subject of a sentence; the predicate of a nominal sentence
Accusative	مَنْصُوب	fatHa (-a, or -an when indefinite)	the direct object of a verb, and various adverbial expressions
Genitive	مَجْرُور	kasra (-i, or -in when indefinite)	the object of a preposition; the second (and later) noun of an idafa

Definite versus indefinite endings

A definite noun (one with ال, a possessive suffix, or standing as the first noun of an idafa) takes the plain short vowel. An indefinite noun takes tanwiin, the doubled vowel, which adds "n".

Case	Definite ending	Indefinite (tanwiin) ending	Example
Nominative	-u	-un	الطَّالِبُ / طَالِبٌ
Accusative	-a	-an	الطَّالِبَ / طَالِباً
Genitive	-i	-in	الطَّالِبِ / طَالِبٍ

All three of الطَّالِبُ, الطَّالِبَ, and الطَّالِبِ simply mean "the student." The ending marks only the word's role.

The ending always goes on the **last letter** of the word.

A present-tense verb ends in damma: يَقْرَأُ، تَعْمَلُ.

Seeing all three cases in one sentence

قَرَأَ الطَّالِبُ الكِتَابَ في المَكْتَبَةِ

qaraʾa T-Taalibu l-kitaaba fi l-maktabati: the student read the book in the library

- الطَّالِبُ takes the nominative ending, since it's the subject: the one doing the reading.
- الكِتَابَ takes the accusative ending, since it's the direct object: the thing being read.
- المَكْتَبَةِ takes the genitive ending, since it's the object of the preposition في ("in").

The sound feminine plural (ـات)

A sound feminine plural never takes fatHa. It has only two endings: damma in the nominative, and **kasra in both the accusative and the genitive**. With tanwiin: ـاتٌ (nominative), ـاتٍ (accusative and genitive).

Case	Definite	Indefinite
Nominative	الطّالِباتُ	طالِباتٌ
Accusative	الطّالِباتِ	طالِباتٍ
Genitive	الطّالِباتِ	طالِباتٍ

شاهَدْتُ الطّالِباتِ في المَكْتَبةِ

I saw the students (f.) in the library: الطّالِباتِ is the direct object, but it still takes kasra.

After a number

The noun after a number takes its case from the number, not from its role in the sentence.

Number	The counted noun	Example
11 to 99	singular, **accusative** (tanwiin -an)	عِشْرُونَ طالِباً
100	singular, **genitive** (second term of an idafa)	مِئةُ طالِبٍ

The noun stays accusative even when the number itself changes. 11 to 19 keep fatha. The tens take ـُونَ in the nominative and ـِينَ after a preposition or as an object, but the noun after them is still accusative singular: أَسْكُنُ مَعَ عِشْرِينَ طالِباً.

Diptotes

Diptotes, which include many proper nouns and certain plural patterns, take no tanwiin and use fatHa instead of kasra in the genitive.

Present-Tense Verb Conjugation

How the present tense is built

The present tense (al-mudaariʿ) wraps the verb root in prefixes and suffixes that mark person, gender, and number. Nearly all verbs use the same prefixes and suffixes.

Full paradigm: shaahada (to watch)

Pronoun	Meaning	Form
	I	أُشَاهِدُ
	you (m. sg.)	تُشَاهِدُ
	you (f. sg.)	تُشَاهِدِينَ
	he	يُشَاهِدُ
	she	تُشَاهِدُ
	we	نُشَاهِدُ
	you (dual)	تُشَاهِدَانِ
	they (m. dual)	يُشَاهِدَانِ
	they (f. dual)	تُشَاهِدَانِ
	you (m. pl.)	تُشَاهِدُونَ
	you (f. pl.)	تُشَاهِدْنَ
	they (m. pl.)	يُشَاهِدُونَ
	they (f. pl.)	يُشَاهِدْنَ

The underlying pattern

- Prefix by person: أ- for "I," ت- for "you" and for "she," ي- for "he" and for "they" (masculine), ن- for "we."
- Suffix by number and gender: nothing extra for the plain singular forms, ِينَ for "you, feminine singular," ـَانِ for both dual forms, ـُونَ for "you/they, masculine plural," and ـْنَ for "you/they, feminine plural."

Other verbs use the same prefixes and suffixes; only the stem vowel varies:

Verb	Meaning	I" form"	he" form"
dhahaba	to go	أَذْهَب	يَذْهَب
shariba	to drink	أَشْرَب	يَشْرَب
ʿamila	to do, to work	أَعْمَل	يَعْمَل
araada	to want	أُرِيد	يُرِيد
aHabba	to like, to love	أُحِبّ	يُحِبّ

Negating the present tense

Negate with لا directly before the verb. The verb does not change.

لا أَذْهَبُ إلى الجَامِعَةِ اليَوْم (I'm not going to the university today). هُوَ لا يَشْرَبُ القَهْوَة (he doesn't drink coffee).

Verbs with a Fixed Preposition

Some verbs are always followed by a particular preposition. The preposition attaches to its object, and a pronoun object becomes a suffix: يَشْعُرُ بِها (he feels it).

Verb	Meaning
يَشْعُرُ بِـ	to feel (something)
يَذْهَبُ إِلى	to go to
يَسْتَمِعُ إِلى	to listen to
يَسْكُنُ فِي	to live in
يَعْمَلُ فِي	to work in

Present tense of يَشْعُرُ بِـ

Pronoun	يَشْعُرُ بِـ
أَنا	أَشْعُرُ بِـ
أَنْتَ	تَشْعُرُ بِـ
أَنْتِ	تَشْعُرِينَ بِـ
هُوَ	يَشْعُرُ بِـ
هِيَ	تَشْعُرُ بِـ
أَنْتُما	تَشْعُرانِ بِـ
هُما (.m)	يَشْعُرانِ بِـ
هُما (.f)	تَشْعُرانِ بِـ
نَحْنُ	نَشْعُرُ بِـ
أَنْتُمْ	تَشْعُرُونَ بِـ
أَنْتُنَّ	تَشْعُرْنَ بِـ
هُمْ	يَشْعُرُونَ بِـ
هُنَّ	يَشْعُرْنَ بِـ

The noun after بِـ is genitive: أَشْعُرُ بِالسَّعادةِ (I feel happiness).

Question Words

Forming a question

Place an interrogative particle at the start of the sentence. Word order does not change.

Particle	Sounds like	Meaning
هَل	*hal*	yes/no questions
مَن	*man*	who?

ما	*maa*	what? (no verb follows)
ماذا	*maadhaa*	what? (verb follows)
كَيفَ	*kayfa*	how?
أَينَ	*ayna*	where?
مَتى	*mataa*	when?
كَم	*kam*	how much / how many?
أَيّ / أَيّة	*ayy / ayya*	which?
لِماذا	*limaadhaa*	why?

ماذا versus ما

Both mean "what." Use ما when a noun follows: ما إسمُكَ؟ (what is your name?). Use ماذا when a verb follows: ماذا تَدرُس؟ (what do you study?).

Question words combined with prepositions

The preposition comes first, before the question word:

Meaning	Arabic
from where?	مِن أَينَ؟
in which?	في أَيّ؟
with whom?	مَعَ مَن؟
to where?	إلى أَين؟
why? (literally "for what")	لِماذا؟
to whom? for whom?	لِمَن؟

hal, and questions with no particle at all

هَل opens a yes/no question. In casual speech it is often dropped and intonation alone marks the question.

Numbers 11 to 100

11 to 19

Two words: the digit, then عَشَرَ. These are the masculine forms.

Number	Arabic	Sounds like
11	أَحَدَ عَشَرَ	*aHada ʿashara*
12	اِثْنا عَشَرَ	*ithnaa ʿashara*
13	ثَلاثَةَ عَشَرَ	*thalaathata ʿashara*
14	أَرْبَعةَ عَشَرَ	*arbaʿata ʿashara*
15	خَمْسةَ عَشَرَ	*khamsata ʿashara*

16	سِتَّةَ عَشَرَ	*sittata ʿashara*
17	سَبْعةَ عَشَرَ	*sabʿata ʿashara*
18	ثَمانِيةَ عَشَرَ	*thamaaniyata ʿashara*
19	تِسْعةَ عَشَرَ	*tisʿata ʿashara*

The tens

Number	Arabic	Sounds like
20	عِشْرُونَ	*ʿishruun*
30	ثَلاثُونَ	*thalaathuun*
40	أَرْبَعُونَ	*arbaʿuun*
50	خَمْسُونَ	*khamsuun*
60	سِتُّونَ	*sittuun*
70	سَبْعُونَ	*sabʿuun*
80	ثَمانُونَ	*thamaanuun*
90	تِسْعُونَ	*tisʿuun*
100	مِئة	*miʾa*

The tens end in ـُونَ in the nominative and ـِينَ in the accusative and genitive (عِشْرِينَ).

Counting nouns

- After 11 to 99 the counted noun is **singular** and **accusative**: خَمْسةَ عَشَرَ طالِباً (fifteen students), عِشْرُونَ طالِباً (twenty students).
- Numbers like 23 put the unit first, joined with وَ: ثَلاثةٌ وَعِشْرُونَ.
- After 100 the noun is singular and genitive: مِئةُ طالِبٍ.

Kaana and Laysa

كانَ (was): past tense

Pronoun	كانَ
أَنا	كُنْتُ
أَنْتَ	كُنْتَ
أَنْتِ	كُنْتِ
هُوَ	كانَ
هِيَ	كانَتْ
أَنْتُما	كُنْتُما
هُما (m.)	كانا

كانَتا	هُما (.f)
كُنّا	نَحْنُ
كُنْتُمْ	أَنْتُمْ
كُنْتُنَّ	أَنْتُنَّ
كانُوا	هُمْ
كُنَّ	هُنَّ

- The endings are the past-tense endings: ـْتُ، ـْتَ، ـْتِ، ـْتُما، ـْتُمْ، ـْتُنَّ، ـْنا، ـْنَ.
- The long vowel shortens before an ending that starts with a consonant: كانَ but كُنْتُ, كُنّا, كُنَّ.
- Subject nominative, predicate accusative: كانَ الطَّقْسُ جَمِيلاً. A prepositional predicate stays as it is: كانَتْ فِي المَكْتَبِ.
- With a subject that follows, the verb agrees in gender only and stays singular: كانَ الطُّلّابُ فِي الصَّفِّ. A plural of things takes the feminine singular: كانَتِ البُيُوتُ قَدِيمةً.

لَيْسَ (is not): present-tense negation

لَيْسَ	Pronoun
لَسْتُ	أَنا
لَسْتَ	أَنْتَ
لَسْتِ	أَنْتِ
لَيْسَ	هُوَ
لَيْسَتْ	هِيَ
لَسْتُما	أَنْتُما
لَيْسا	هُما (.m)
لَيْسَتا	هُما (.f)
لَسْنا	نَحْنُ
لَسْتُمْ	أَنْتُمْ
لَسْتُنَّ	أَنْتُنَّ
لَيْسُوا	هُمْ
لَسْنَ	هُنَّ

- The forms for هُوَ، هِيَ، هُما، هُمْ keep لَيْسـ (لَيْسَ، لَيْسَتْ، لَيْسا، لَيْسَتا، لَيْسُوا); every other form, including هُنَّ (لَسْنَ), uses لَسْـ.
- The predicate is accusative: لَسْتُ مُتَرْجِماً, لَسْنا مُوَظَّفِينَ. A prepositional predicate stays as it is: لَيْسَتْ فِي البَيْتِ.

Reading: Maha's Story

عائِلة والِدِي كَبِيرة، أَعْرِف أَقارِبِي مِن الصُّوَر وَالرَّسائِل. هَذا عَمِّي مَحْمُود وَأُسْرَتُهُ، وَهَذا عَمِّي عادِل وَأُسْرَتُهُ، عَمِّي عادِل ضابِط كَبِير فِي الجَيْش. وَهَذا عَمِّي أَحْمَد وَأُسْرَتُهُ، هُوَ فِي الحَقِيقة اِبْن عَمّ والِدِي. عَمِّي أَحْمَد أُسْتاذ فِي كُلِّيّة العُلُوم السِّياسِيّة بِجامِعة القاهِرة، وَهُوَ يُدَرِّس الآن فِي جامِعة العَيْن بِالإِمارات العَرَبِيّة المُتَّحِدة. وَهَذِهِ عَمَّتِي فاطِمة وَزَوْجُها وَاِبْنُها وَبَناتُها.

My father's family is big; I know my relatives from pictures and letters. This is my uncle Mahmoud and his family, and this is my uncle Adel and his family; my uncle Adel is a high-ranking officer in the army. And this is my uncle Ahmad and his family; he is actually my father's cousin. My uncle Ahmad is a professor in the college of political science at Cairo University, and he is now teaching at Al Ain University in the United Arab Emirates. And this is my aunt Fatima, and her husband, her son, and her daughters.

Self-Check

Cover the right column and answer, then check.

A. Say it in Arabic

Write the family word.

my father's brother	عَمِّي
my mother's sister	خالَتِي
my mother's brother's son	اِبْن خالِي
my father's sister's daughter	بِنْت عَمَّتِي
my (paternal) uncle's wife	زَوْجة عَمِّي
my grandmother	جَدَّتِي
my relatives	أَقارِبِي

B. Make an idafa

Put the nouns together correctly.

مَكْتَب الأُسْتاذ (the professor's office)	(مَكْتَب / الأُسْتاذ)
عائِلة والِدِي (my father's family)	(عائِلة / والِدِي)
جامِعة القاهِرة (Cairo University)	(جامِعة / القاهِرة)
صُورة العائِلة (the family picture)	(صُورة / العائِلة)
كُلِّيّة العُلُوم السِّياسِيّة (the college of political science)	(كُلِّيّة / العُلُوم السِّياسِيّة)
اِبْن عَمّ والِد مَها (Maha's father's cousin)	(اِبْن / عَمّ / والِد / مَها)

C. Fix the mistake

Each idafa breaks a rule.

جامِعة القاهِرة (no ال on the first word)	الجامِعة القاهِرة
مَكْتَب أُسْتاذِي (no ال when the last word has a possessive ending)	مَكْتَب الأُسْتاذِي
صُورة عائِلَتِي (the possessive goes on the last word only)	صُورَتِي العائِلة
كُلِّيّة الطِّبّ (no ال on the first word)	الكُلِّيّة الطِّبّ

D. Whose?

Turn each pair into one word.

رِسالَتُها	(رِسالة / هِيَ)
أَقارِبُنا	(أَقارِب / نَحْنُ)
كُلِّيَّتُكُمْ	(كُلِّيّة / أَنْتُمْ)
زَوْجَتُهُ	(زَوْجة / هُوَ)
صُوَرِي	(صُوَر / أَنا)
عَمُّكِ	(عَمّ / أَنْتِ)
جَيْشُهُمْ	(جَيْش / هُمْ)
اِبْنُكَ	(اِبْن / أَنْتَ)

E. Give the plural

اِبْن	أَبْناء
رِسالة	رَسائِل
ضابِط	ضُبّاط
قَرِيب	أَقارِب
صُورة	صُوَر
عَمّ	أَعْمام
كُلِّيّة	كُلِّيّات
زَوْج	أَزْواج
عِلْم	عُلُوم
جَيْش	جُيُوش

G. How do you pronounce the ة?

مَدِينة نِيويُورْك	madīnat Nyūyūrk (ة → t, not the last word)
صُورة العائِلة	ṣūrat al-ʿāʾila (the ة in صُورة is t; the final ة is silent)

جامِعة القاهِرة	jāmiʿat al-Qāhira